

HELD GROUND

The King's Crusade — Module Eight

OVERVIEW

Vindana is held, the coalition is exhausted in the specific, good way an army gets after a fight it won, and this module's entire job is to let that feeling breathe before the campaign asks anything hard of the party again. There is no required plot beat here. A second member of the royal house is found and freed along the way, but it happens inside the same relaxed, comic register as everything else in this module rather than as inserted business. Core scenes run three to three and a half hours; this is one of the few modules in the campaign where running short is not a problem — let the table linger.

LEVITY, PLANNED IN

This campaign's relief valves are designed rather than accidental, and this module is where that design shows up structurally. Play every scene here for warmth first: reunions, absurd logistics, recurring characters getting real room. If a DM feels the urge to raise the stakes, resist it — Module Nine will do that job. This one's job is rest.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Long Exhale	45–60 min	Vindana at rest. Recurring characters welcome.
2. The Grain Ledger War	30–45 min	Absurd logistics. Comedy, not combat.
3. The Magistrate	60–75 min	The second rescue, played as a caper. DC table below.
4. What the Name Costs	20–30 min	A quiet scene with Xavier. Closes the module.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Nothing in this module is a trap, a test, or a delayed complication. Vindana is genuinely secure, the coalition is genuinely at ease for the first time since Module One, and the Magistrate's rescue in Scene 3 is genuinely as easy as it plays — the occupation's administration in a freshly-fallen city is in real disarray, and a party willing to use its own paperwork against it will find that disarray works entirely in their favor. If a DM feels this module is too easy, that is correct and intentional.

DM Only: Xavier has still not directly addressed being called the Wyvernheart as of this module's start — the gap held open in Module Seven continues into Scene 4, which is the one place this module allows real feeling. Do not let the earlier scenes anticipate it.

SCENE 1: THE LONG EXHALE

Vindana's taken harbor district has become, within days, the loudest and most cheerful place the coalition has occupied since Harrowmark. Let the party spend real time here.

Someone has chalked a running tally on the side of a captured warehouse — days since the siege, casks emptied, and, unofficially, a tally of how many times a passing soldier has tried and failed to get a straight answer out of Huntmaster Brenna Vane about whether she actually rode south for the war or just to see the fuss for herself.

If Module One was played, Brenna Vane has arrived with a handful of Greywatch hands, drawn south by rumor of the Wyvernheart with an expression that suggests she will never admit that is the reason. If Module 2A or 2B was played, Sera Vosk or Garrick Hollow can likewise turn up here, already embedded in the coalition's logistics or scouting corps. Use whichever recurring faces the table has earned; this scene's only job is reunion and warmth.

SCENE 2: THE GRAIN LEDGER WAR

Vindana's occupation-era grain levy records — thousands of receipts, quotas, and permits, exactly the bureaucracy Module Three showed the party in miniature — have fallen into coalition hands whole, and nobody sent to sort them was remotely prepared for the scale of it.

Three different coalition quartermasters are shouting at each other over a single warehouse of requisitioned grain, each one certain their own contingent's paperwork takes precedence, while an increasingly desperate Elduvish clerk — pressed into the coalition's service rather than freed from it, which nobody seems to have noticed yet — tries to explain that the numbers do not actually add up for anyone.

Let the party resolve this however they find funniest: mediate, cut through it with authority, or simply steal a wagon of grain themselves while the argument continues. No mechanical stakes and no wrong answer. If a perceptive party notices the pressed clerk's situation and does something about it — a small kindness, not a rescue — let that pay forward into how Elduvaine's ordinary people regard the coalition later.

SCENE 3: THE MAGISTRATE

Among the captured administration's own records is a name the party will recognise if they have been paying attention, and it is not filed under prisoners. Ottoline Vahn — magistrate of the Braid for a hundred and sixty years, the Ward's great-aunt by a marriage nobody now living attended, and a gnome somewhere past two hundred — has been held under house arrest in a Vindana townhouse she insists on calling her chambers, kept comfortable and thoroughly bored by an occupation that was too disorganised before the siege to know what to do with her and is considerably more disorganised now.

She receives the party at a desk, in what is unmistakably an office, with the weary patience of somebody who has spent three years winning arguments against clerks a tenth her age. "You'll want papers," she says, before anyone has explained themselves. "Everybody wants papers. Fortunately I have spent three years becoming extremely good at papers. Sit down. Do not move the third pile."

RUNNING THE SCENE

This is a caper, not a fight. The Magistrate's household is guarded by a skeleton crew of occupation clerks and one or two soldiers, none of them expecting trouble in a freshly-fallen city, and she herself is entirely capable of walking out the front door if the party can produce (or forge) plausible transfer papers — Vindana's administrative chaos, established in Scene 2, means nobody is checking closely. A DC 13 Deception or Forgery-adjacent check (use whatever tool proficiency a character has) produces convincing papers; a DC 10 Persuasion check talks a guard into not looking too hard at them regardless.

If the party would rather simply walk in and take her by force, that works too and is considerably less interesting — a DM should let the Magistrate herself gently steer the party toward the caper option if asked, since she has clearly been planning her own exit for some time and has opinions about the tidiest way to manage it.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Resolve the quartermasters' dispute without violence	Persuasion / Insight	10	Easy
Forge or produce convincing transfer papers	Deception / an appropriate tool proficiency	13	Moderate
Talk a guard out of scrutinizing the papers	Persuasion	10	Easy
Notice the pressed Elduvish clerk's actual situation	Insight / Perception	13	Moderate

SCENE 4: WHAT THE NAME COSTS

Late, with the day's business done, Xavier finds the party somewhere quiet — away from the harbor's noise, away from anyone keeping official record of the conversation.

"They've started calling me something," he says, not quite a question. "I keep waiting for someone to explain it to me properly and nobody will. I remember the dragon. I remember being fairly sure I was about to die. I don't remember deciding to be brave about it — I remember being too frightened to think of anything else to do." He is quiet for a moment. "Is that what the songs are going to say happened? Because I'd rather they didn't, if it's all the same."

Let this be a real conversation rather than a scene to resolve. Xavier is not fishing for reassurance and does not need the party to tell him he is a hero; he genuinely does not know yet how he feels about the name, and the party's honest reaction — whatever it is — matters more here than any mechanical outcome. This scene needs no check and produces no loot. It is the module's actual point, arriving last, exactly where a session built on deliberate levity has been heading since Scene 1.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

Three Years of Filing expands the ledger war and adds twenty minutes. Putting the Light Back is additive, takes ten, and should not be cut — it is the beat the whole module is built around.

THE PUZZLE: THREE YEARS OF FILING

Ottoline Vahn fought her captivity by filing, and won, and the consequence is that the occupation of Vindana produced the most complete administrative record in Elduvaine and then had to rely on it. The party needs one document out of it. She will help, at her own pace, and her pace is the puzzle.

"You want the carriage authorisations. Everybody wants the carriage authorisations. They are not filed under carriage, they are not filed under authorisation, and they are not filed under Norvatch, and if you tell me why you want them I will tell you where they are, and if you do not, we can spend a pleasant afternoon and you can find them yourself."

The registry is filed by the issuing office, not by subject, which is standard Elduvish practice and is baffling to everyone else. Four offices issued paper in Vindana and the party can work out which from any docket they already hold:

Office	Issued	Docket mark
The Levy	Grain, fodder, and the published quarterly rate	A single stroke, top right
The Harbour	Everything that moved by water, in or out	Two strokes and a date
The Garrison	Permits for persons, and passes	A stamp, always smudged
The Keeper's Office	Anything touching the Archive or the quarries	No mark at all, which is itself the mark

The carriage authorisations went out by water, so they are Harbour, and they are filed by date, and the date the party wants is the week Norvatch's volume tripled — which they can get from Morgarth's harbourmaster, or from the counting-house manifests in this module, or by asking Ottoline the question she is waiting to be asked.

DM Only: the unmarked fourth office is the real find and the party should stumble on it while looking for something else. Anything issued by the Keeper's Office carries no docket mark, because the Keeper's Office was never part of the civil registry and never needed one — which means every quarry order, every Archive requisition and every light-stone consignment for three years is sitting in a drawer that nobody has thought to look in, unmarked, because it always was. Ottoline knows. She has been waiting three years for somebody to notice, and she will not point at it, because pointing at it is not how a magistrate establishes anything.

SET PIECE: PUTTING THE LIGHT BACK

The city has been dark for fourteen months and the coalition holds it, and on the fourth night somebody works out that the wall will still take a charge.

"It is a gnome from Cairn Ithel and two Auberitz sappers and a Concord priest of Aurine who has no business being on that scaffold, and between them they pour about four hours of lamplight into eleven feet of the inner wall. It holds. It comes up slow, the colour of late afternoon, and it spreads maybe thirty feet along the course and stops. Eleven feet of a city that used to do this from the ground up on every clear night. Somebody on the harbour steps starts crying and does not stop and nobody says anything about it."

It is not a victory and everyone present knows the arithmetic: four hours of lamp for eleven feet of wall, against a city that held six centuries of afternoons for free. The stone is not repaired. The stone is being manually filled, one small stretch at a time, by people who will be dead long before the second street is done.

They do it anyway. They do it every night for the rest of the occupation of the city, and by the time the party leaves Vindana about two hundred feet of the inner wall is lit, and the party will be able to see it from the road.

DM Only: this is the levity module and this is not a levity scene, and it should sit in the middle of an evening that is otherwise warm and loud and full of terrible singing. Do not build to it. Let somebody mention it in passing, let the party wander over, and let them stand there. Then go back to the singing. The contrast is the whole design of the module and this is the beat it is built around.

NPC PROFILES

OTTOLINE VAHN, THE MAGISTRATE

A gnome somewhere past two hundred, dry as a ledger, and entirely unbroken by three years of house arrest — if anything sharpened by it. Ninian's great-aunt by a marriage nobody now living attended, which is the sort of thing old Elduvish houses are full of. Speech: precise, faintly amused, allergic to being underestimated by people who had every opportunity to know better. She fought her captivity with the only weapon she has ever needed and won: three years of correctly formatted objections, appeals and requests for clarification, every one of them lawful under the occupation's own published code, which have cost the administration of Vindana an estimated four hundred clerk-days and produced a written record of the occupation so complete that the occupation came to rely on it.

Open thread: freed, she is a formidable and very funny recurring NPC — a DM can use her as a source of administrative chaos turned against the occupation in any later module, or simply as comic relief who happens to also be dangerous in exactly the way nobody expects from an old woman with a ledger.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

DOWNTIME, PROPERLY, FOR THE FIRST TIME

This is the first stretch of the campaign long enough and safe enough for downtime, and the sourcebook's six options under Downtime on a March are all available in a held city. Each is meant to produce a scene rather than a die roll, and a DM running this module should offer them by name rather than waiting to be asked.

Stand a watch — four hours on a picket line with one other person, chosen by the player, and the DM asks what they talked about. It is the single most productive downtime action in the campaign and it costs nothing. Work the column, and earn the goodwill of Auberitz's people, which converts directly into supply and being told things early. Drink with the levy, for one rumour that is true and one that is not, with no indication which. Keep the observance, at a Ninefold House or a wayside shrine, and be seen doing it, which in this coalition is a political act whichever one is chosen. Train with the watch, if Brenna Vane is here, and take the advantage it grants against the next large flying thing. Or copy, if anybody has Archive training, at about a page a week of something Vale would rather nobody had.

DM Only: keep the observance is the one worth pushing in this module specifically. Vindana is a freshly-taken Elduvish city with a Concord army sitting in it and a Tenth Work chapter house being framed in a street that had an Observance on it last year. A player character who chooses one of those two on a given evening has made a statement, and somebody will comment, and it should cost nothing and be remembered.

THE COUNTING-HOUSE

Vindana is a port, and Norvatch trades through ports. Three streets back from the harbour, a Norvatch counting-house has been open through the entire occupation and is open now, under the coalition, with the shutters down and a clerk at the desk and absolutely nothing to apologise for. This is the one cold scene in an otherwise warm module, and the module can carry it.

The factor does not stand up. "We are open," he says, in the tone of a man confirming the weather. "We were open last month as well. If your king would like to discuss terms, my principals will hear him — and if he would rather not, the arrangement we have runs another nine months and I would ask you not to interfere with lawful carriage."

Everything he says is true and none of it is deniable. Norvatch has broken no agreement with the coalition because it never made one. The goods moving through that house are Elduvaine, by weight, sold under a contract with the occupation that predates the crusade's arrival by three years. A party that wants to seize the ledgers by force can — and will find them impeccably kept, entirely legal, and worth

rather less taken than bought, because what they actually need is the house's cooperation in reading them.

DM Only: the ledgers are the campaign's clock, and this is where the party first sees the physical object. Do not let them buy it here — the factor is not authorised and says so. What he will do is send word to Doria Kell, which is what sets up Module Ten. If the party takes them by force anyway, they get numbers they cannot interpret and a Norvatch house that will deal with them thereafter strictly, correctly, and never generously again. That is a real consequence and not a punishment; play it exactly that flat.

THE BETTING LEDGER RETURNS

If Module One was played and Brenna Vane is present per Scene 1, her old betting ledger from Greywatch makes a reappearance, now taking wagers on considerably higher-stakes nonsense — how long the peace will hold, whether the Magistrate and the Ward will get along, anything the table finds funny. Pure levity, no stakes.

A QUIET WORD WITH THE WARD

If the Ward was rescued in Module Four, let her and the Magistrate meet for the first time here — two members of a divided royal house with different ideas about what should follow the war, meeting in a moment that has no pressure on it yet. Play their first exchange for warmth and a little friction, not conflict; save the real disagreement for later in the campaign, per the royal house's established canon division on the question.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **How the Magistrate was freed.** Caper or force — track which. A caper leaves the occupation's administration none the wiser for a while longer, which a DM can use later; a forced rescue is noisier and gives the coalition's presence in Vindana a slightly harder edge sooner.
- **Whether the party noticed the pressed clerk in Scene 2.** A small thread, but worth tracking — it is the campaign's recurring question about the occupation's ordinary people, in miniature, again.

LOOT

- **The Magistrate herself.** As with the Ward in Module Four, the module's actual reward — a second freed royal, formidable in her own register, and a second real voice in whatever the royal house eventually decides about Elduvaine's future.

- **A warehouse's worth of grain.** However the Grain Ledger War was resolved, the coalition ends this module better supplied than it started it — modest, practical, not a coin windfall.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*